

# Let your apps socialise!

>> Making your apps 'social' can enhance their capabilities at multiple levels. We'll tell you why and how you could tap into your users' social context to build a better user experience>

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Online social networking is one of the most popular means to stay connected with your friends and family; but by no means does it end at that. While social platforms have been around for some time, they have witnessed tremendous growth both in their capabilities and the number of users using them, and are gradually creeping into other commonly used digital platforms as well. With its growing reach, it has opened up a completely new kind of opportunity that has the potential to reinvent the conventional 'self-sufficient' model of applications.

Now you can port a good part of your users' social networking experience and its associated data into your apps, which can help you enhance your apps' capabilities as well as revenues. With the kind of options made available by the social networking platforms to developers, making your apps truly personalised & 'social' has never been easier.

## How do social networking platforms interact with external apps?

The best part about making your apps social is that you don't need to do all the hard work yourself. All you need to do is open up a bit to them!

In addition to usual status updates and tweets, people indirectly generate a lot of useful information when they interact with other entities in their online social networking environment. Every interaction taking place inside a social networking platform, the 'objects' involved and their meta data have IDs associated with them. In some cases, this information is summarised into concise structures or graphs. External agents can interact with these objects and graphs via APIs that are carefully designed to be secure as well as easy-to-use for developers.

For actions that require access to user's private information, the requesting app should be registered with the platform and should be authenticated via protocols such as OAuth by the user in order to publish or access information to or from the social platform.

Social platforms allow you to ask for a huge variety of information about users, such as attributes from their profile, their preference or the list of their friends or followers. However, this doesn't mean you should ask for all of it! There is usually a strong inverse relationship between the amount of information requested and the grant of authorisation by users. Hence, you should carefully assess your app's requirements before finalising the set of information that you'd want your users to authorise. For instance, if your app specialises in job openings, asking for a user's relationship status will almost certainly lead to rejection of authentication by the user!



## How does going 'social' make things any better?

Adding a social layer to an app greatly increases user engagement, as there is a certain feeling of assurance and security when your users interact with entities that have a familiar feeling about them. Building great apps is much more than simply delivering services and content to your users. It's about putting your users at the centre and building everything around them. That effectively means building ground up with the user as the base. By placing your users and their social context at the centre of your projects, you intuitively come up with better ways to provide quality content and services to your users, and you formally upgrade your app to the next generation of 'social apps'. Moreover, by making your app social, you render service to your app as well as its users.

### Add value to your users

'Social' apps make your users feel like they have an identity. This greatly improves user's willingness to engage with your content. You can personalise your content for each user by harnessing their social context and by making things more relevant to them. In addition, you hand them the opportunity to 'socialise' over your content or app by sharing their feelings with their friends and family, which is what humans fundamentally want to do.

### Add value to your app

Making your app social puts it in a position of clear advantage over other 'not-so-social' apps. It adds a sense of seamlessness between